

Asia before Colonial Times

Francis Bond

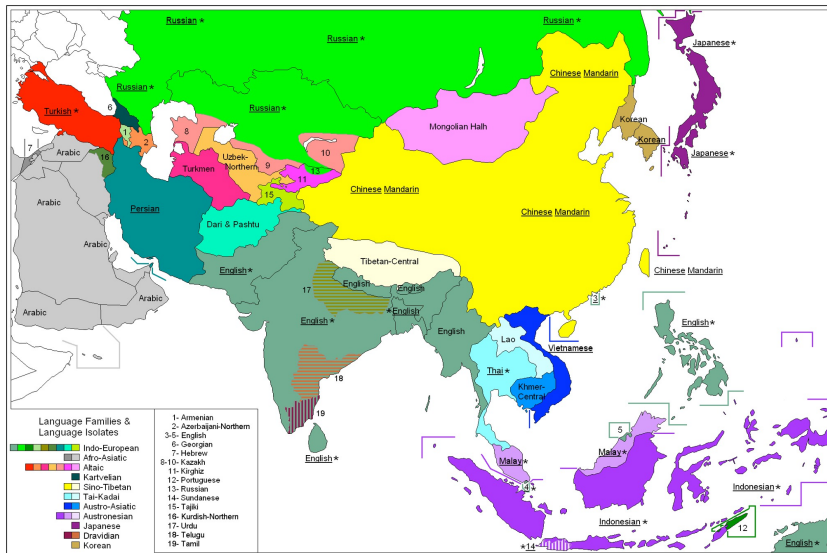
based on slides by František Kratochvíl

2026

Overview

- 1 Language Families of Asia
- 2 Geography and Climate
- 3 Crops and Domestication
- 4 Lexical Borrowing

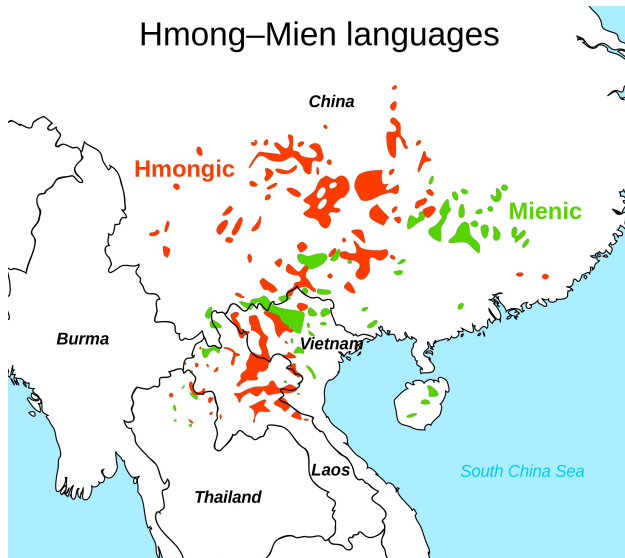
Major languages of Asia



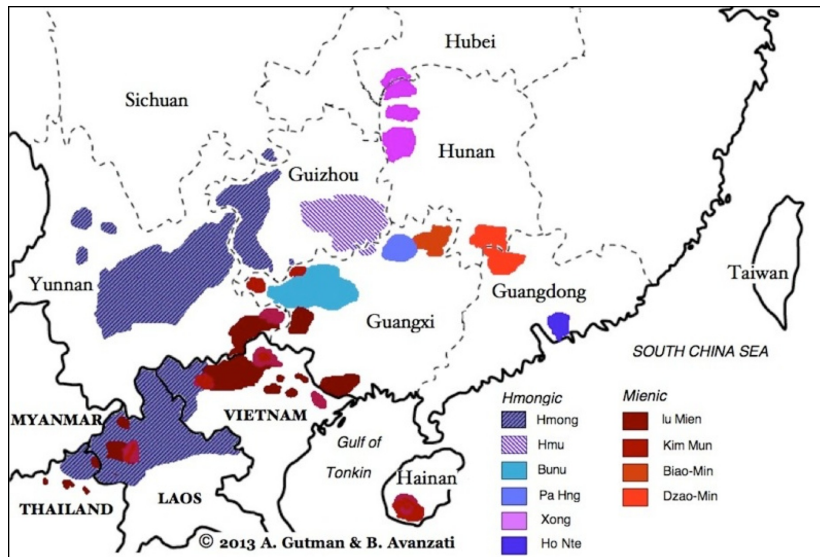
Austro-Asiatic family



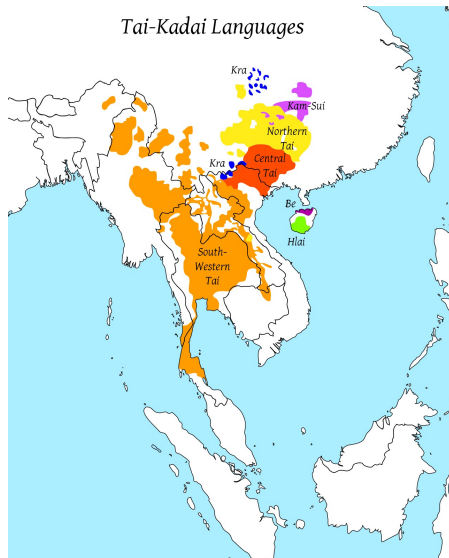
Hmong-Mien family



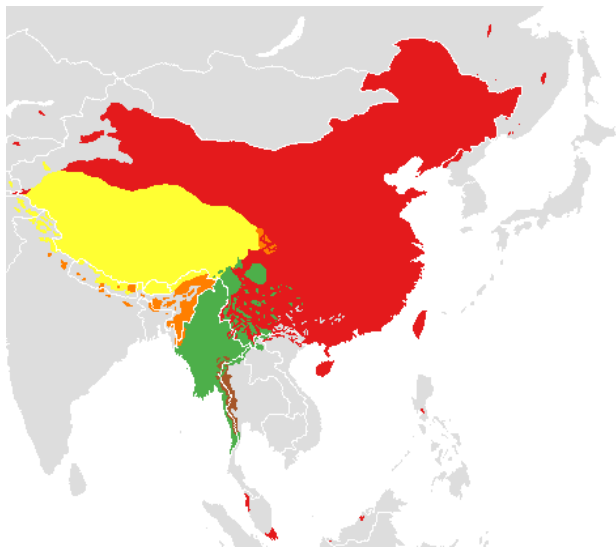
Hmong-Mien family



Tai-Kadai family (probably a branch of Austronesian)

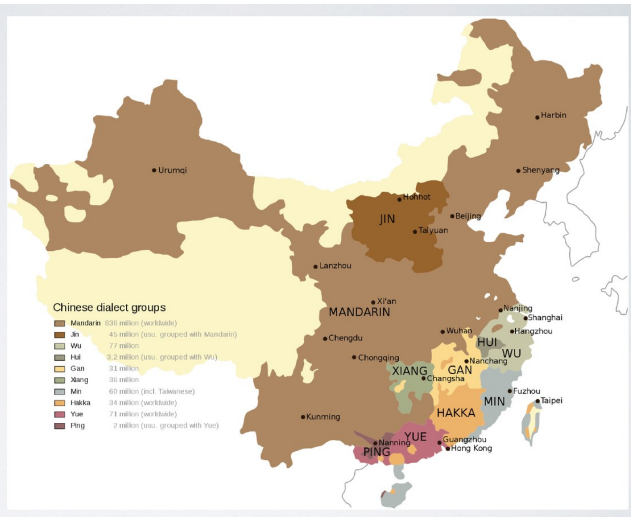


Sino-Tibetan family

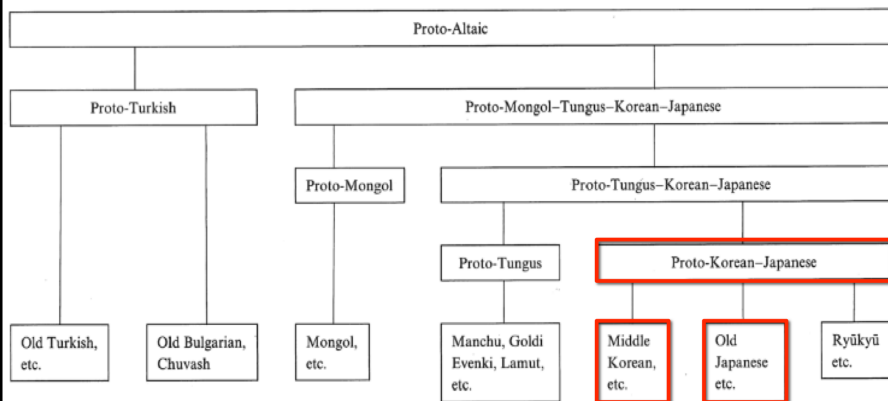


■ Sinitic ■ Tibetic ■ Lolo-Burmese ■ Karenic ■ other (Kuki, Chin, Naga, ...)

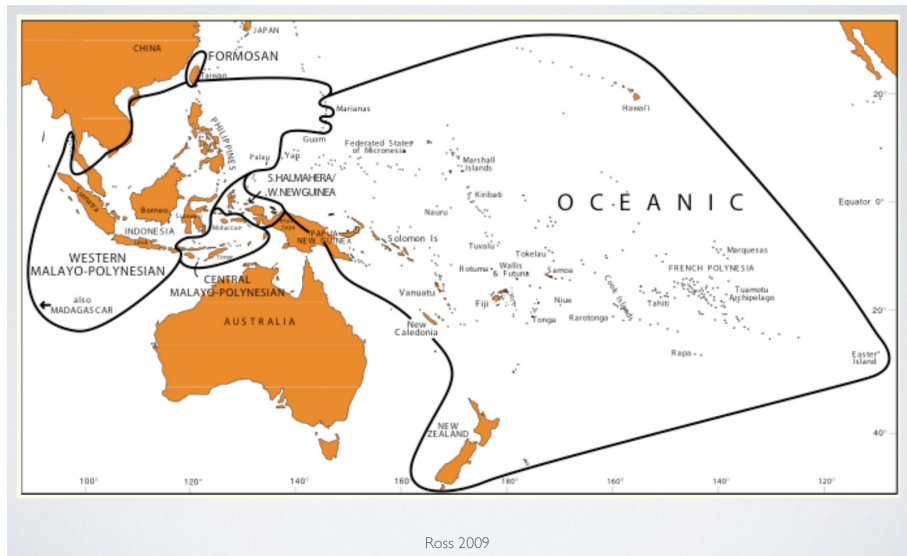
Sinitic branch



Altaic hypothesis



The integrity of the Austronesian language family



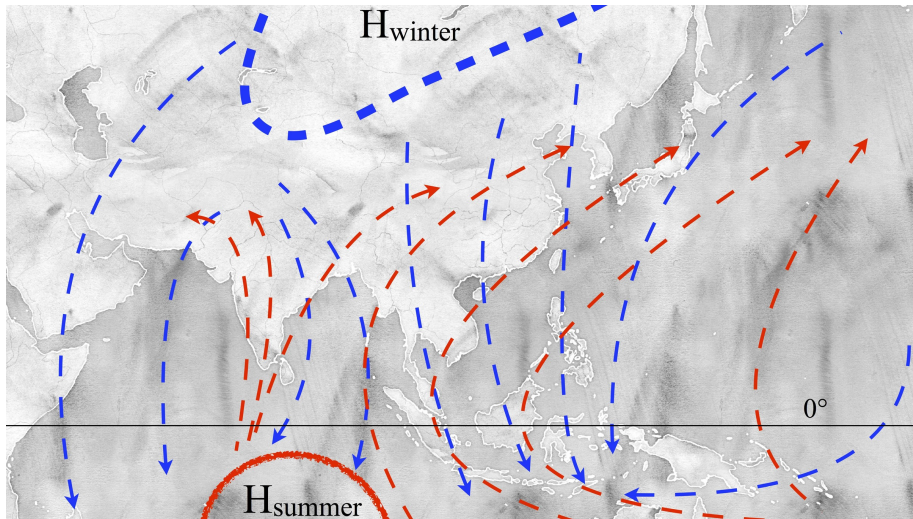
Relief of East and Southeast Asia



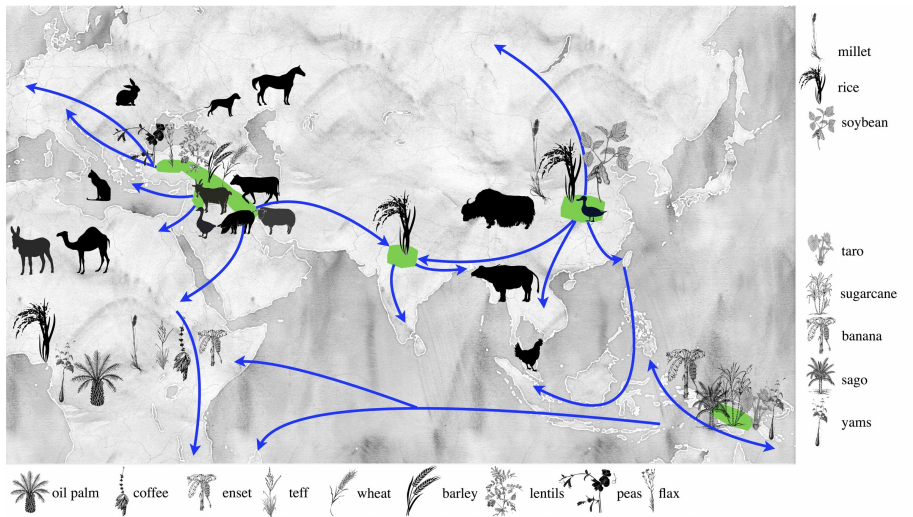
Relief of mainland Southeast Asia



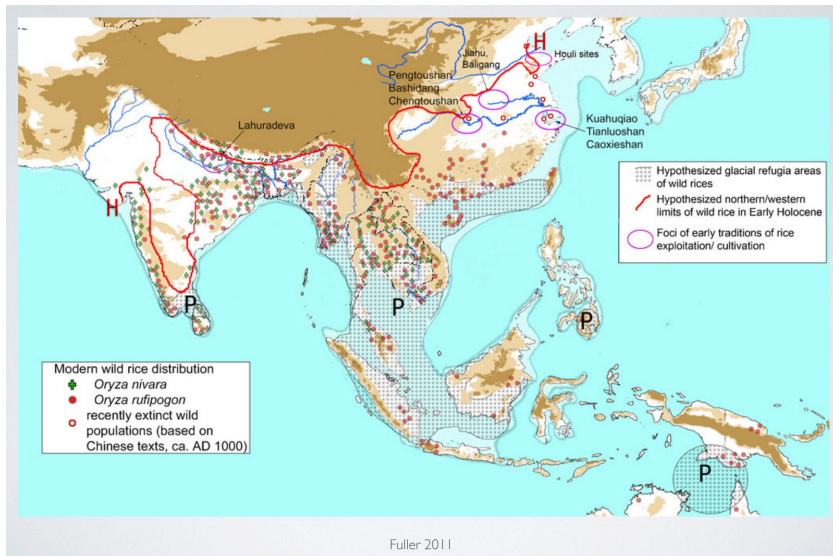
Monsoon patterns



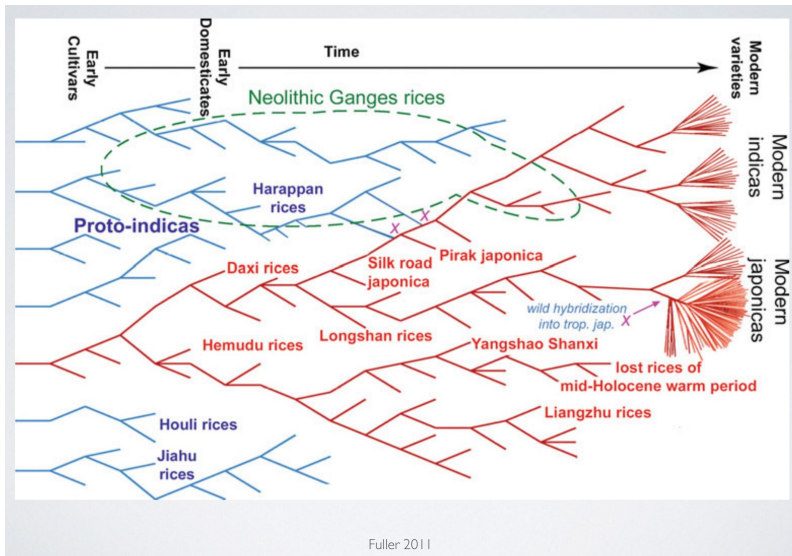
Cultural crops



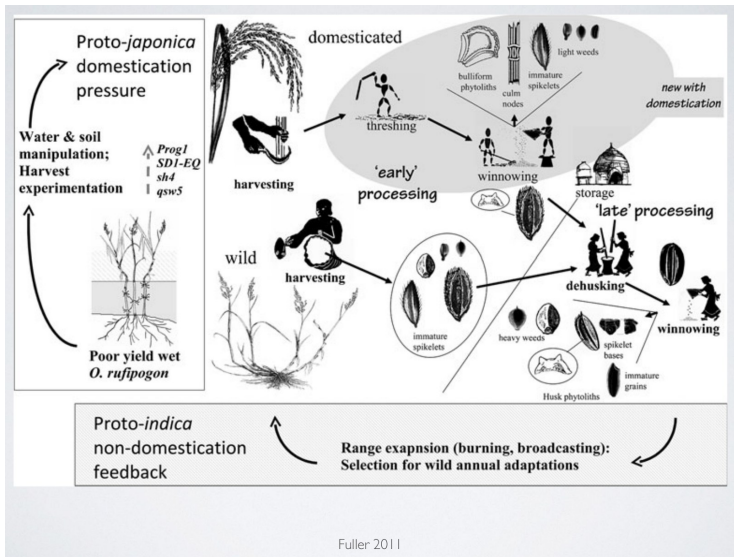
Last glacial period sea levels and natural refugia of wild rice



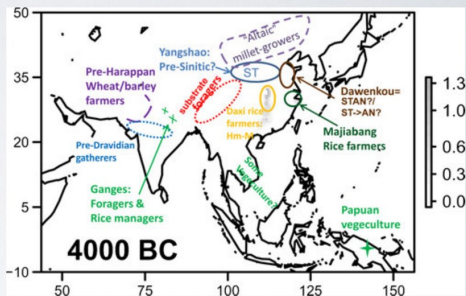
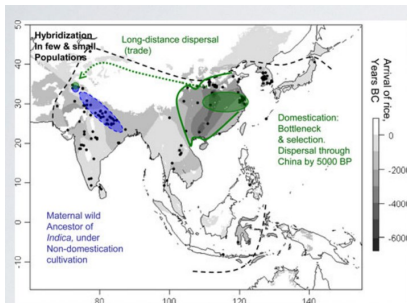
Genetic diversity of rice



Domestication pressures on rice

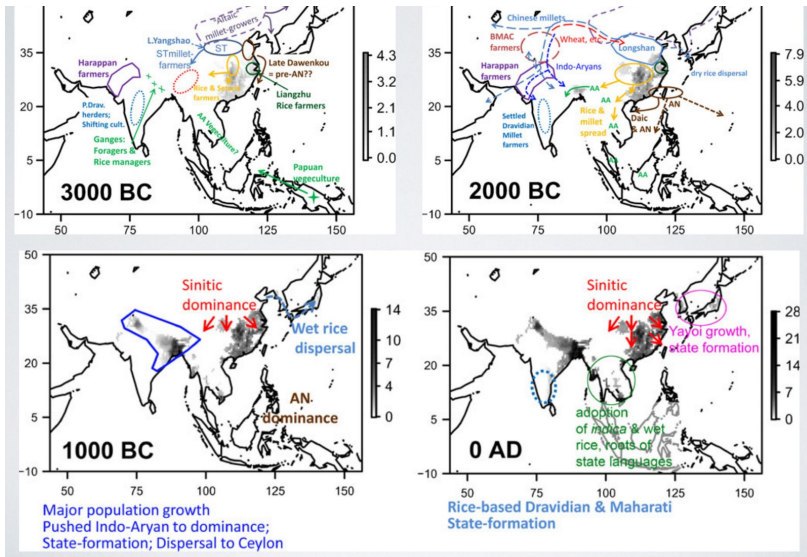


Spreading of rice hybrids

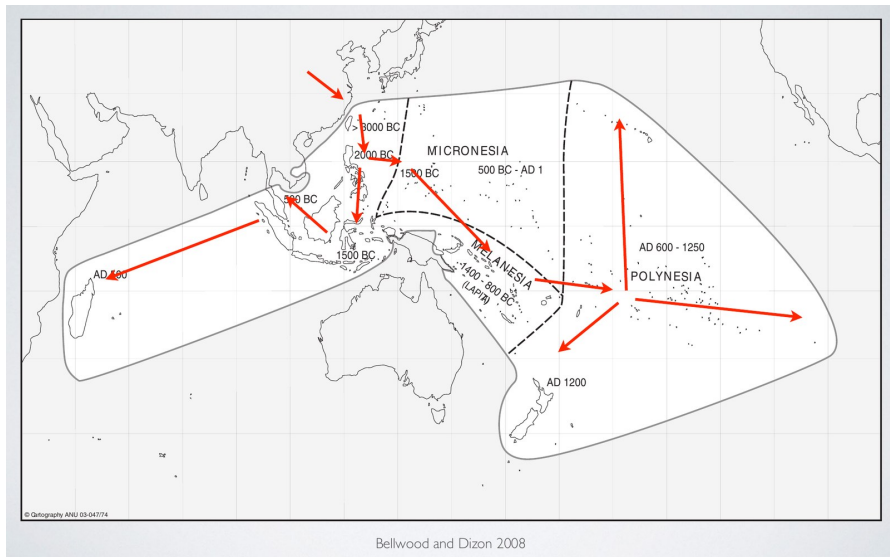


Fuller 2011

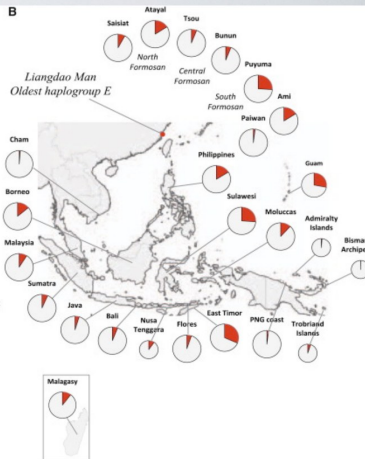
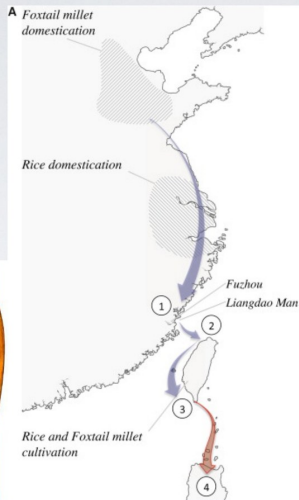
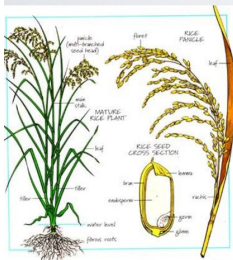
Spreading of rice hybrids



Reconstruction of Austronesian expansion



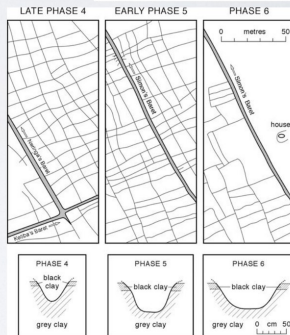
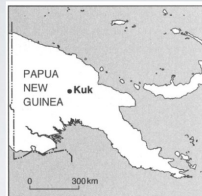
Millets



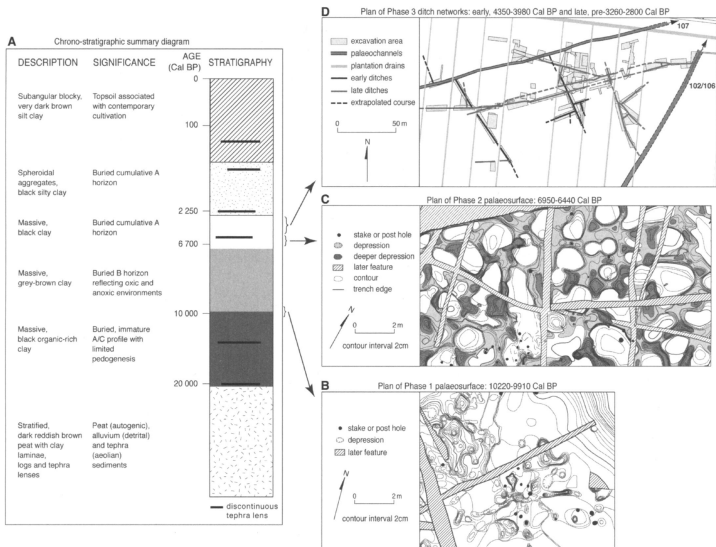
Suggested Migration Route for Early Austronesians Into and Out of Taiwan and the Worldwide Distribution of Haplogroup E1 (A) Geographic regions in China of foxtail millet domestication (source: Ko et al. 2014)

Taro domestication

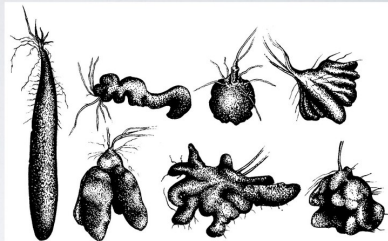
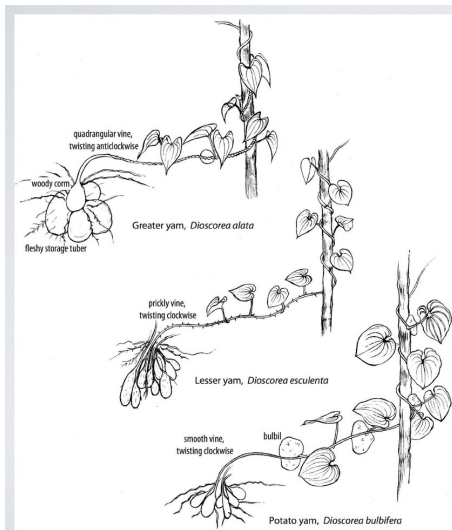
Multidisciplinary investigations at Kuk Swamp in the Highlands of Papua New Guinea show that agriculture arose independently in New Guinea by at least 6950 to 6440 calibrated years before the present (cal yr B.P.). Plant exploitation and some cultivation occurred on the wetland margin at 10,220 to 9910 cal yr B.P. (phase 1), mounding cultivation began by 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. (phase 2), and ditched cultivation began by 4350 to 3980 cal yr B.P. (phase 3). Clearance of lower montane rainforests began in the early Holocene, with modification to grassland at 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P. Taro (*Colocasia esculenta*) was utilized in the early Holocene, and bananas (*Musa* spp.) were intensively cultivated by at least 6950 to 6440 cal yr B.P.



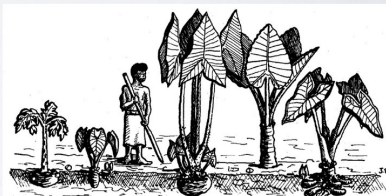
Taro domestication



New Guinean domestications: tubers



Yams (*Dioscorea alata*)

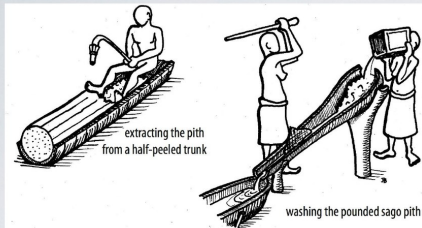


Colocasia

Alocasia

Taro (*Araceae*) and *Amorphophallus*

New Guinean domestications: sago



New Guinean domestications: banana



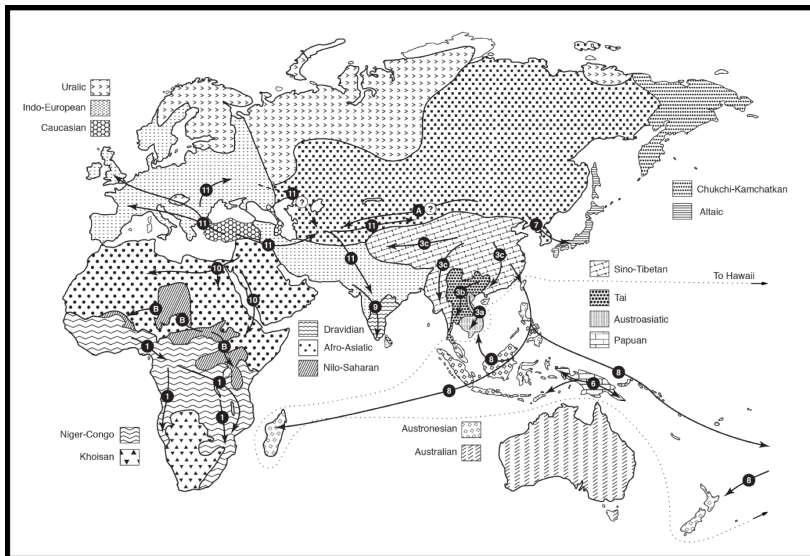
Over 100 new accessions of wild and cultivated bananas were obtained from a wide geographic region including West New Britain, East New Britain, New Ireland, Western Highlands, East Sepik, Madang and Milne Bay



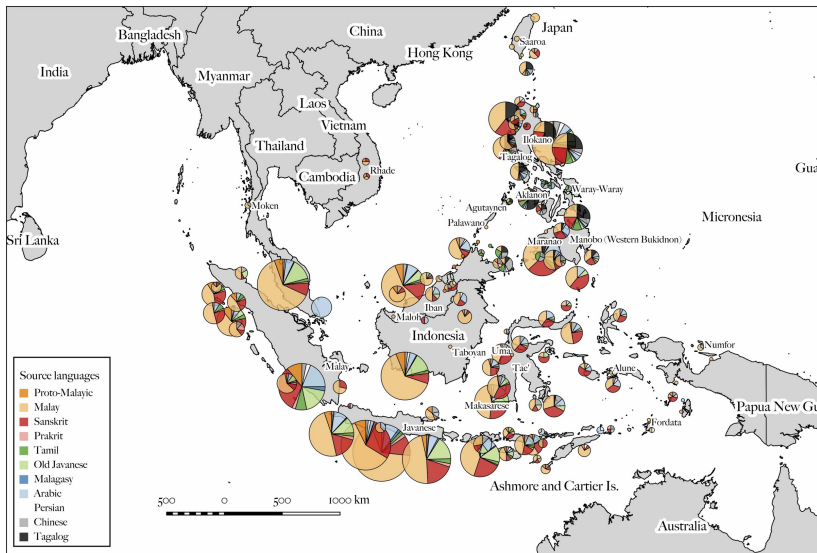
New Guinean domestications: sugar cane



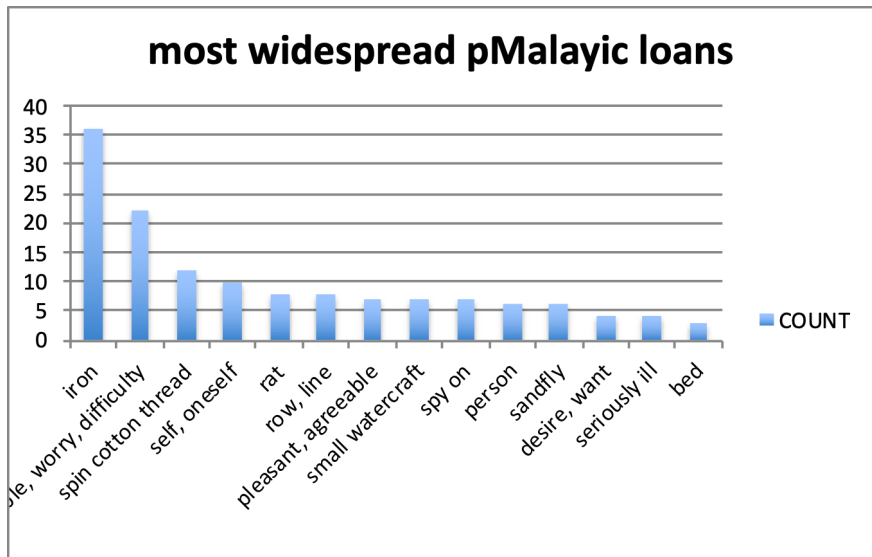
Cultural crops and language family expansions



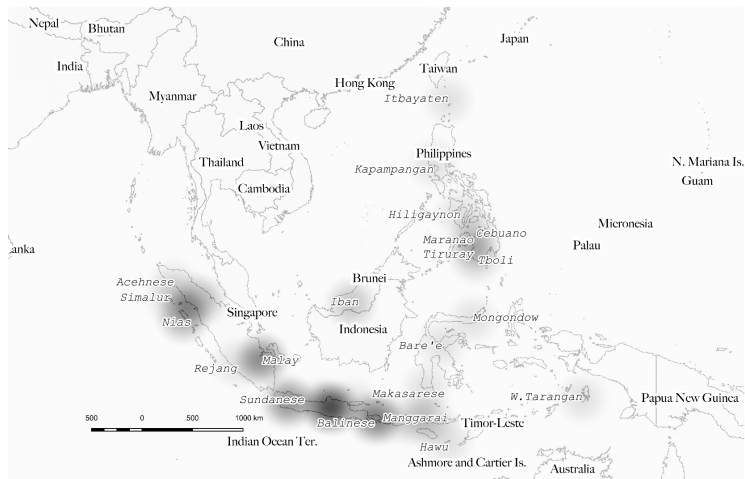
Lexical borrowing in Austronesian



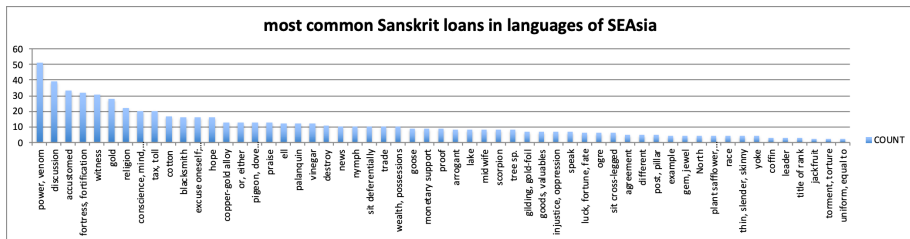
Malayic loanwords



Indic loanwords



Indic loanwords



[illegible]

May Siva bless those who take delight in the language of the gods

Grantha and Pallava scripts

Phoenician	Aramaic	Value	Brahmi	Value
𐤀	𐤁	*	𑀀	a
𐤂	𐤃	b [b]	𑀁	ba
𐤄	𐤅	g [g]	𑀂	ga
𐤆	𐤇	d [d]	𑀃	dha
𐤈	𐤉	h [h], M.L.	𑀄	ha
𐤊	𐤋	w [w], M.L.	𑀅	va
𐤌	𐤍	z [z]	𑀆	ja
𐤏	𐤐	h [h]	𑀇	gha
𐤑	𐤒	t [t]	𑀈	tha
𐤔	𐤕	y [j], M.L.	𑀉	ya
𐤖	𐤗	k [k]	𑀊	ka
𐤙	𐤚	l [l]	𑀋	la
𐤛	𐤜	m [m]	𑀌	ma
𐤞	𐤟	n [n]	𑀍	na
𐤡	𐤢	s [s]	𑀎	sa
𐤤	𐤥	' [ʔ], M.L.	𑀏	e
𐤧	𐤨	p [p]	𑀐	pa
𐤩	𐤪	ś [sʰ]	𑀑	ca
𐤬	𐤭	q [q]	𑀒	kha
𐤱	𐤲	r [r]	𑀓	ra
𐤴	𐤵	ś [ʃ]	𑀔	śa
𐤸	𐤹	t [t]	𑀕	ta

Indian scripts are
derived from Greco-
Phoenitian alphabeth

ீ ு ூ ௃ ௄
 k kh g gh ṇ
 ௅ ெ ே ை ௉
 c ch j jh ṇ
 ொ ோ ௌ ் ௎
 ṭ ṭh ḍ ḍh ṇ
 ௐ ௑ ௒ ௓ ௔
 t th d dh n
 ௕ ௖ ௗ ௘ ௙
 p ph b bh m
 ௚ ௛ ௜ ௝ ௞
 y r l v ṛ
 ௟ ௠ ௡ ௢
 ś ṣ s h

௣ ௤ ௥ ௦ ௧
 a ā i ī u ū
 ௨ ௩ ௪ ௫
 r ṛ ḷ ḹ
 ௬ ௭ ௮ ௯
 e ai o au
 ௰ ௱
 ṁ ḥ

PALLAVA
SCRIPT

Austronesian scripts derived from Indian

Kawi
(700-1500 AD)

Javanese
(still in use)

Balinese
(still in use)

Specimen of an Ancient Javanese Inscription.

ဤစာတော်ကို နေသံဃာ် ဝိဝာဏာရုံ၌ ရွာကွက် ဖြစ်သော နာမံ ဝိဝိဇ္ဇာ

Alphabets not arranged according to the Devanagari classification

MODERN JAVANESE ALPHABET.

Open Consonants, which the Vowels a or o are always understood to follow.

he no cho ro ke do lo so wo lo po do jo yo nyo mo go bo to ngo
𐌺𐍃 𐌹𐍆 𐌸𐍂 𐍂𐍅 𐌵𐍇 𐌳𐍅 𐌻𐍅 𐍀𐍅 𐍅𐍅 𐌻𐍅 𐍀𐍅 𐍉𐍅 𐍎𐍅 𐍁𐍅 𐌿𐍅 𐍂𐍅 𐌿𐍅

Consonants following Consonants, without a Vowel intervening.

ho ne cho ko le te zo w lo po do jo nya me bo to

m d p n l q x o u j m b c s t

Contractions of Consonants.

h r r medial y ng marks the termination of a word in a consonant

Great Letters used on occasions of Ceremony

^{yo} 
^{to} 
^{so} 
^{do} 
^{go} 
^{so} 

Vowels and orthographical marks

$$\triangle j \leq i \quad i \quad j$$

Beginning of a Drama.

Period.

Hā Nā Cā Rā Kā

ᨀᩢ᩠ᨦ ᨀᩢ᩠ᨦ ᨀᩢ᩠ᨦ ᨀᩢ᩠ᨦ ᨀᩢ᩠ᨦ
 Dā Tā Sā Wā Lā





 Mā Gā Bā Ngā





 Pā Jā Yā Nyā

Cham
(still used)

Consonants

က ကာ ဂ ဂာ ဂွ ဂွ ဇာ ဇာ ဇာ ဇာ ဇာ ဇာ
ka kha ga gha ngue nga cha chha ja jha nhue nha nhja

တ	ဖ	သ	န	မ	ည	ဉာ	ပ	ပာ	ဖာ	ဘ	မ္မ	မာ
ta	tha	da	dha	nue	na	dda	pa	ppa	pha	ba	bha	mue ma

bbā ya rā lā vā ssa sa ya

Vowels

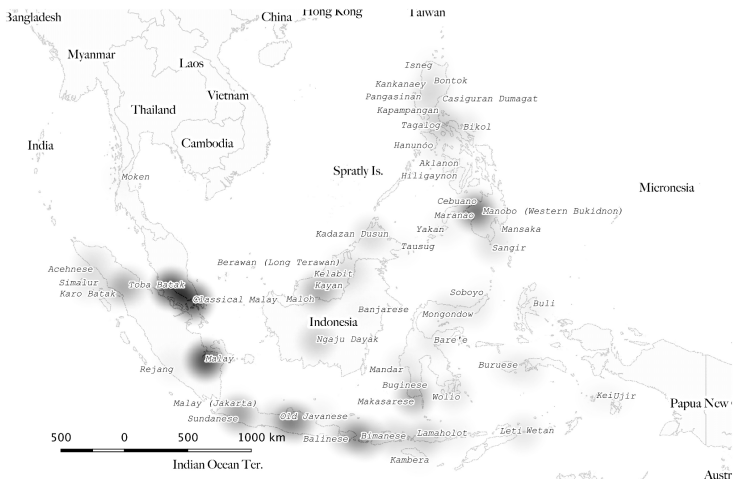
Vowel diacritics

အာ ဣ ဧ အ ဝ် ဝိ ဝီ ဝိ ဝု ဝူ ဝဉ္စ ဝေ ဝေး

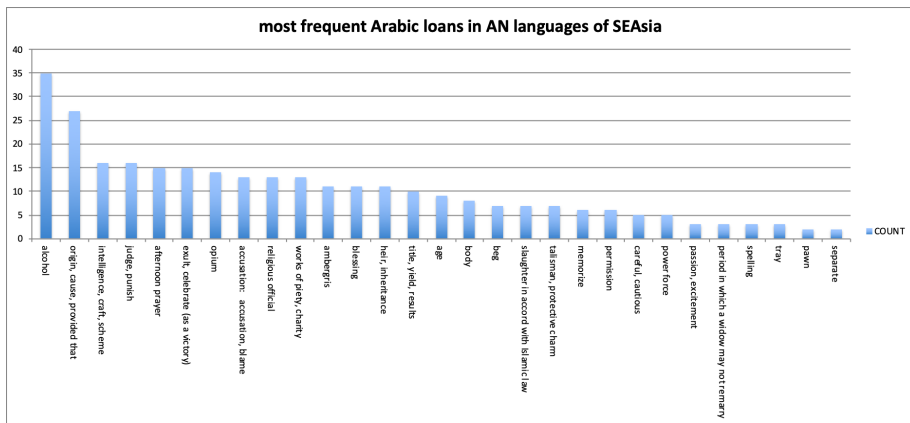
a i u e al o a i li ei u uu ou oe ooe e

ee o oo ai au ue uu

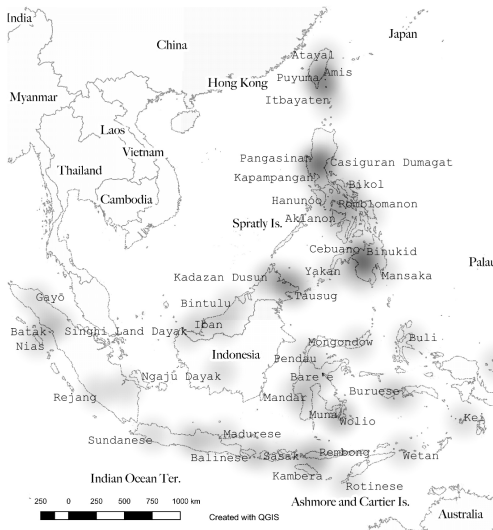
Arabic loanwords



Arabic loanwords

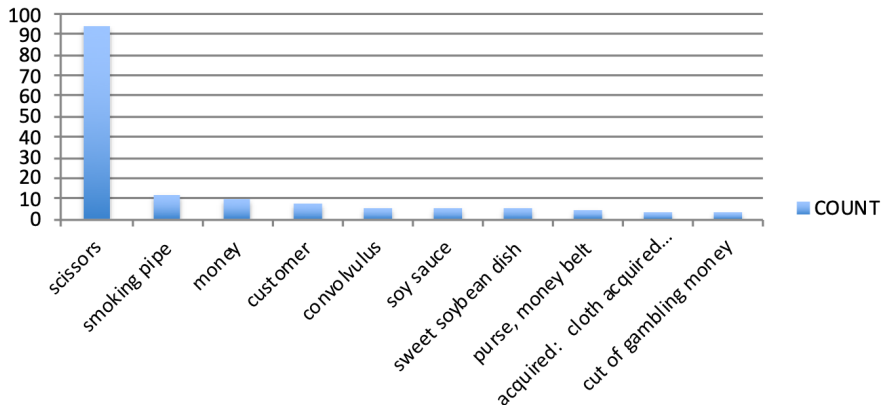


Chinese loanwords

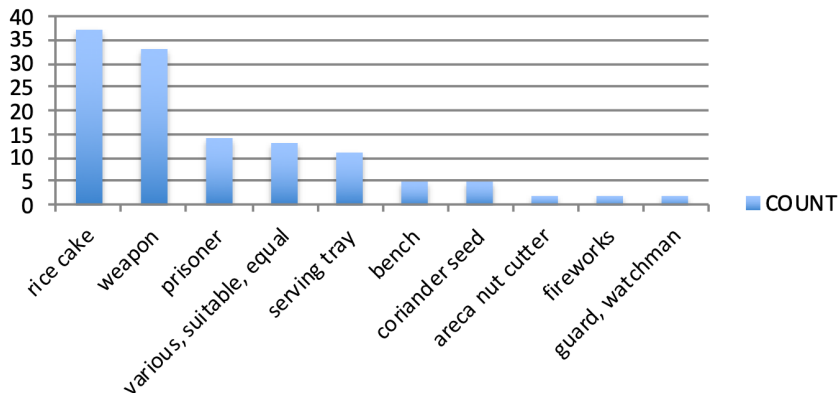


Chinese loanwords

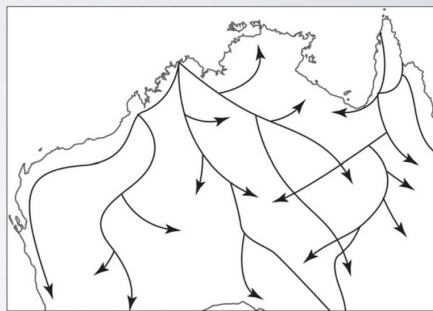
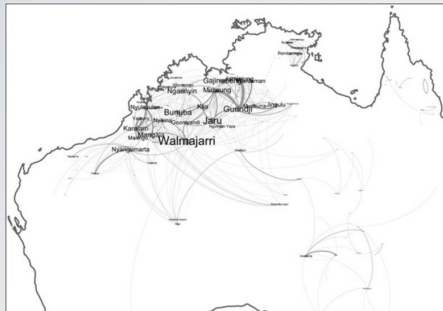
Most widespread Chinese loans



Most common Tamil loans in languages of SEAsia



Wanderwörter in Australian languages



References I

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- Sather, Clifford. 2006. Sea nomads and rainforest hunter-gatherers: foraging adaptations in the Indo-Malaysian archipelago. In Peter Bellwood (ed.), *The Austronesians: Historical and Comparative Perspectives*, 245–285. Canberra: ANU E Press.
- Fuller, Dorian Q. 2011. Pathways to Asian civilizations: tracing the origins and spread of rice and rice cultures. *Rice* 4: 78–92.
(the source of the rice maps and phylogenies above)

Acknowledgement

- These slides are a re-typeset version of **Asia before Colonial Times** by **František Kratochvíl**, given for *Lingvistika asijských jazyků* (DAS/LAS) on 18 February 2021.
- The figures are his, or are reproduced in his slides from the sources named on each slide and listed at the end.
- Rebuilt here in the format of the rest of the course so that it can be maintained and revised alongside the other weeks. Any errors introduced in the rebuilding are mine.
- Thanks to František for making the material available.